The lad was in my line of vision, waiting with a pen and a piece of paper in familiar fashion. As I approached, the trap was sprung. ‘I don’t want your stupid autograph,’ he said, pulling the paper away with a flourish as I stood there, looking silly. Oh, how they laughed. Suddenly, another boy appeared, as if out of nowhere.

He, too, was waving a piece of paper. ‘Go on, sign it for the kid,’ the adults in the crowd crowed, relishing my dilemma. I knew what was coming and kept walking, to general derision. It was the ultimate no-win situation. You can’t have a go back, because it is pointless and unbecoming. Why expose yourself to further ridicule simply because you play for a certain team or country?

Australians are big on theatrical patriotism. I admire the intensity with which the nation identifies with its athletes, and, to be fair, Andy Flower’s broader strategy as we set out to climb the world rankings sought to connect the England team with the aspirations of supporters, and our traditions as fellow citizens.

I’ve felt the emotional pull of those bonds, and can understand the veneration of the Baggy Green. It has captured the imagination of the Australian public and seeped into the global consciousness. Various sweat-stained incarnations, worn by such bona-fide legends as Steve Waugh, are presented in museums as if they are holy relics. But part of me agrees with Jimmy Anderson when he observes: ‘It’s just a fucking hat.’

It’s a brand, built on imagination and history. Its timeline can be traced back to the Don and the other greats. I’m proud that my England cap links me to Hutton in the way Waugh’s is supposed to link him to Bradman, but we haven’t made a point of embracing the wider significance of what is, after all, a piece of kit.

That doesn’t mean the 161 times I walked out to play for England in a Test match weren’t very special, acutely personal occasions. I know where my caps are, apart from one, which appears to have been spirited away by the Borrowers on the farm. They are associated with my debut and other milestones, since they were presented in twenty-five-Test blocks. My mum has one. They carry my England number, 630.

They are important, but they are not intrinsic to my pride as an England player. I recognize the yearning for meaning that leads to all the talk about symbolism, but could honestly give away all my kit, because it is just a